

Great buildings

The first great buildings were constructed for worship or for protection from invaders. In more recent times, many grand buildings are public spaces such as galleries and museums, or towering skyscrapers of offices and hotels.

c.2560 BCE

GREAT PYRAMID AND SPHINX

The Great Pyramid was built as a tomb for Egyptian Pharaoh Khufu, and the Sphinx for his son, Khafre. Both were originally covered with smooth white limestone, and would have glittered in the sunlight.

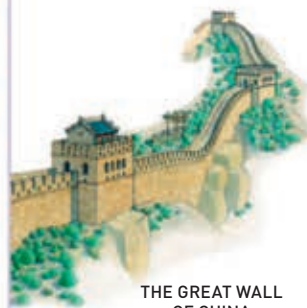


THE GREAT PYRAMID AND SPHINX AT GIZA, EGYPT

c.700 BCE

GREAT WALL

The Great Wall of China was built to keep out invaders. Various Chinese rulers extended it over hundreds of years, and it now stretches for an incredible 21,197 km (13,170 miles).



THE GREAT WALL OF CHINA

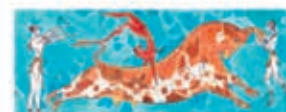
c.1900 BCE

PALACE OF KNOSSOS

This was the largest centre of the Minoan civilization on the Greek island of Crete. Here, religious ceremonies may have been performed and political issues debated. By uncovering the remains, experts have worked out what the buildings would have looked like.



ARTIST'S IMPRESSION OF THE PALACE BUILDINGS



COPY OF A FRESCO FOUND AT KNOSSOS

1883

SAGRADA FAMILIA

This Roman Catholic church is Barcelona's most famous building. It was designed by the Spanish architect Antoni Gaudi, who died in 1926 when only a quarter of the church was built. It is expected to be completed by 2026.



SAGRADA FAMILIA, BARCELONA, SPAIN

1840

HOUSES OF PARLIAMENT

The United Kingdom's centre of government was built on the site of a palace, which burned down in 1834. The remains were incorporated into the new Gothic-style building. Construction took 30 years, and its architects died before completion.



THE HOUSES OF PARLIAMENT, LONDON, UK

1714

CHRIST CHURCH

This London church is one of six designed by Nicholas Hawksmoor in a style called English Baroque. It fell into disrepair in the 20th century but has been restored to its original glory, and its white stone facing gleams in the sunshine.



CHRIST CHURCH, LONDON, UK

1632

TAJ MAHAL

The Taj was built to be an elaborate jewelled tomb for the beloved wife of Mughal emperor Shah Jahan. It is known for its perfect symmetry: it is exactly as wide as it is high.



THE TAJ MAHAL, AGRA, INDIA

1930

EMPIRE STATE BUILDING

It took around 3,400 workers to complete the construction of this 103-floor Art Deco skyscraper in just 410 days. It was the world's tallest building until 1972, and remains New York City's most famous landmark. Every year, there is a race to the 86th floor.



SYDNEY OPERA HOUSE, AUSTRALIA

1959

SYDNEY OPERA HOUSE

A multi-venue performing arts centre, Sydney Opera House was designed by Danish architect Jorn Utzon in a style called Modern Expressionism. The building's distinctive look comes from its one million self-cleaning, glazed white tiles.

1971

POMPIDOU CENTRE

Housing a library, museum of modern art, and a centre for music research, the Pompidou is a high-tech arts centre. The different coloured parts are not just ornamental: green pipes indicate plumbing; blue ducts are for climate control; elevators, escalators, and staircases are red.



POMPIDOU CENTRE, PARIS, FRANCE



MODEL OF THE POMPIDOU

1993

GUGGENHEIM MUSEUM

The Guggenheim in Bilbao, Spain, is one of the world's most admired and popular buildings. Its architect, Canadian Frank Gehry, intended its shiny curves to appear random and sculpture-like.



THE GUGGENHEIM, BILBAO, SPAIN

EMPIRE STATE BUILDING, NEW YORK CITY, USA